Thoughts on spatially enabled census data with the location of households pinpointed by GPS

Wine D. Langeraar
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Sanur, Bali, Indonesia

As census mapping manager in Timor-Leste I pioneered and implemented a technique of putting all of the country's households on the map with GPS during the 2004 Population and Household Census, and subsequently linking the census database with the household locations. This turned out to be a triumph, and a first world-wide (I was interviewed by CNN and the Australian ABC as a result). It provided the Government with powerful tools for development. Patterns emerged otherwise never noticed, and correlations and causalities became apparent and could be acted upon with surgical precision, thus saving the Government time and lots of money (See the 'Looney Map' sent separately as an example). The GPS for Census technique was presented in Sydney during the 2006 International Statistical Conference as an invited paper. A number of countries in Africa, Middle East, South East Asia and Pacific have subsequently asked me to implement my GPS for Census technique.

The GPS technique - putting all households on the map and linking all census content to the household points – has obvious advantages. But there are dangers. Unscrupulous governments could use the data not for the advantage of the population but for despotism. I have subsequently received information that this indeed occurred in Timor-Leste. The spatially-enabled census database I put together in Timor-Leste was used to trace insurgents during the 2006 irregularities there. I have thus come to the conclusion that if this technique is used for the benefit of the people and not as an instrument of repression then an overriding condition must be in place that keeps location aspects separate from content. This is difficult to enforce because the recipient government will become owner of the data.